

# 6 THINGS I'M DOING TO LEARN JAPANESE WITHOUT A TUTOR

I'm N2. In December I sit the entrance exam for an art university in Tokyo, entirely in Japanese. **I have never written a Japanese composition in my life.**

This isn't a method that's been proven on anyone. It's what I'm actually doing, written down while I'm still in the middle of it — so you can watch whether it works.

## 01 Input daily. Output weekly. Minimum.

Most self-learners only consume — anime, textbooks, apps — and then can't produce a sentence when it matters. Understanding and producing are separate skills and one does not become the other on its own.

**Why this is first:** it's the mistake I made for years. I could read comfortably and still froze when I had to write something down.

## 02 Learn kanji through radicals, not strokes

語 isn't fourteen arbitrary lines. It's 言 (speech) + 五 + 口 (mouth). Around fifty radicals will decompose most kanji you meet into three or four parts you already know.

Then build a story from the parts. 休 is 亻 (person) + 木 (tree) — a person resting against a tree. Sillier sticks better, and the ones you invent yourself stick best, because inventing them is what encodes it.

## 03 Mine sentences. Don't memorise word lists.

Take words from things you're actually reading or watching, and keep the whole sentence around them — not the isolated word.

**The reason:** an isolated word gives you a definition. A sentence gives you the shape it appears in, which is the thing you need when you're the one writing.

## 04 Cap Anki at 20 new cards a day

The failure mode of spaced repetition isn't forgetting. It's opening the app to four hundred reviews, closing it, and never going back.

**Small and permanent** beats ambitious and abandoned. Twenty a day is seven thousand cards a year, which is more than you need.

## 05 Speak before you're ready

Everyone waits until they're good enough. There is no such point — the readiness comes from the speaking, not before it.

Free options exist. HelloTalk, language exchange apps, Discord servers. None of them cost anything and all of them are uncomfortable for about two sessions.

## 06 Track something you can count

Days studied. Compositions written. Cards reviewed. Pick one and make it visible.

**Motivation is unreliable** and it will leave you somewhere around week six. A number you can see doesn't.

## ONE THING THIS LIST CAN'T DO

Everything above, you can do alone. There's one thing you can't: see your own mistakes.

You cannot reliably find your own errors in a language you're still learning — which means it's entirely possible to practise the same wrong thing ninety times and get faster at being wrong. At some point you need another pair of eyes on your output. A language exchange partner will do it for free.

**I'm doing all six of these right now, four months out from an exam I might not pass. You'll see the scores either way.**